

abilities or gained a new “mask” that unlocks a new area. Each area has certain objectives you must complete before taking on the big bad boss of the area. It’s a tried and tested formula that works well.

Your weapon in this journey is the staff that you can use for melee combat and it also doubles up as a bow. The combat in the game may be slow at the beginning offering limited moves, but once you get the ability to upgrade your moves, and the diversity in enemies increases, the combat becomes a lot of fun.

You have the “rot” which are these cute and cuddly creatures. At the beginning of any encounter, the “rot” gets scared and hides. As you deal more damage to your foes, you build up a courage meter that lets you perform a special move with the rot. This could be a ground slam, or the rot distracts an enemy or fetches health for you. You can only perform a single action until you find more rot, so whether you decide to use a special attack or regenerate health is a crucial decision in the early parts of the game. As you find more rot, the number of special moves you can do increases but you still need to build up for a move by attacking enemies.

Speaking of enemies, they are quite varied in the game, especially the boss fights. There are quite a few of them, and once you have defeated a boss, they reappear throughout the game alongside normal enemies adding some challenge to the gameplay. This “recycling” of the bosses isn’t overused and provides a welcome challenge, especially later on in the game when you have unlocked more combat moves.

Your traversal abilities also grow during the course of the game. While you start with abilities like double jump, you will gain the ability to throw a “bomb” at glowing objects in the

MOAR!

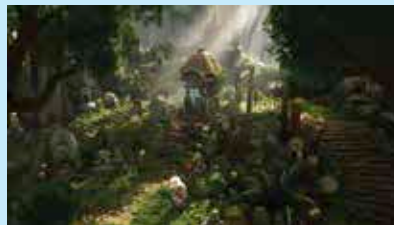
TESTED ON
PS5

DEVELOPER
Ember Lab

PUBLISHER
Ember lab

PLATFORMS
PS4, PS5, PC

PRICE
₹3,330 (PS5)
₹939 (PC)



world to build new paths. The last act in the game has some of the best platforming sequences and kept me at the edge of my seat.

Kena: Bridge of Spirits is quite a challenging game even at the normal difficulty level. It’s challenging enough but not ruthless. For those that want to explore the world and enjoy the story, know that you can drop the difficulty anytime in the game.

To help you navigate the world is a handy map that’s very easy to read. While the game offers fast travel, I’d recommend taking the long road. You never know when you come across a rot or collectable hat you have missed along the way.

GRAPHICS AND AUDIO

While the Pixar reference may be over-used to describe Kena: Bridge of Spirits, there is no better way to describe the cute and cuddly look of the game. It’s nothing short of spectacular with bright vibrant colours spread throughout the village, characters with signature big eyes that are very expressive and the cute and cuddly rot that surrounds you.

Kena’s character design and animations deserve special mention. From her purposeful run to the combat animation, it’s all extremely well executed. Some of the bosses in the later part of the game also deserve special mention. From their ruthless design to their aggressive body language in combat, it’s all so immersive.

While the game looks visually stunning on the PS5, the only gripes I have with it are the few invisible walls I encountered and some stutters during the cutscenes. It felt as though the cutscenes were playing at a lower frame rate. But these are in no way any deterrent to the overall visual presentation of the game.

Moving over to audio, there is a signature flute that plays when you cleanse an area and the flute also has a signature tune for the foes once you’ve freed their spirits. There is also the high octave music that kicks in during combat and considering you are in a village; the game is also full of natural sounds adding to the immersion. The voice acting again is also spot on, nothing short of an animated feature film.

VERDICT

Kena Bridge of Spirits is a good AA platforming action-adventure game overall. It is surprising that this is Ember Lab’s first offering as a game dev. The game has an engaging story, fun combat and a setting nothing short of a AAA animated movie. While some will argue about the limited combat or the short campaign, I say, the game scratches an itch that gamers like me have - an affordable, fun, single-player game with engaging combat and head-scratching puzzles that can be beaten over one weekend. *